



Running Your Buyer Interviews

A short guide for Assembly AI clients using Interview Mode

You have chosen to run interviews instead of surveys. That is the higher-value path. Interviews surface the reasoning behind an answer, not just the answer, and that reasoning is what the C3 Method turns into positioning.

This guide covers what to do before, during, and after each conversation so the interviews you run can be analyzed properly.

Not sure whether to interview or survey this group? Both work, and most clients use both. As a rule: interview the customers you lost (they rarely complete a survey but will often take a call) and your best few current customers. Survey your own team and your prospects, where you need breadth more than depth. The companion survey guide has the full breakdown.

Before you start

Download your Interview Guide from Survey Builder. Switch to Interview Mode and export the PDF. It contains every question in order, grouped by the seven stages of the buying decision, with three probing follow-ups under each one.

Plan for 45 to 60 minutes per interview. The guide is built for that length. Rushing means thin answers in the later stages, which are usually the most valuable ones.

Interview all four groups if you can. Your own team, current customers, customers you lost, and prospects who have not bought yet. The gap between how your team thinks buyers decide and how buyers actually decide is the single most useful thing this process reveals, and you only see it if you talk to both.

Choosing which current customers to interview

You cannot interview everyone, and picking at random wastes the effort. Within your current customers, prioritise these four types:

TYPE	WHO THEY ARE	WHY THEY ARE WORTH AN HOUR
Most profitable	Best margin, not simply the biggest invoice	They reveal what people will happily pay for, and what they never questioned the price of
Most loyal	Renew without drama, stayed with you through a problem	They tell you what actually creates retention, which is rarely the thing you think
Most influential	Send you referrals and open doors to new customers	They can articulate your value to someone else, which is the closest thing to your real pitch
Highest growth potential	Small today, could be much bigger	They show you where the relationship is going before it gets there

Aim for **one from each category**, and up to three if you have the time. Four good conversations across four different reasons for being a good customer beats eight with people who all look the same.

Note who is who when you send us the transcript. Knowing that one interviewee is your most profitable customer and another is your biggest referrer is what lets us show you where those groups **disagree**, which is usually the most useful thing in the whole analysis.

One important limit. Every category above is a customer who likes you. If these are the only people you talk to, you will hear a reassuring story that confirms everything you already believe. **Customers you lost and prospects who have not bought are still separate groups, and still required.** The four categories are for choosing among your current customers, not for choosing who to talk to overall.

People say yes more often than you expect

The hardest part of this process is usually the part in your own head, right before you send the request.

Being asked for your opinion is flattering. Prospects, current customers, and the ones who chose someone else are generally glad to be asked, and many are curious what you learn. What stops them is almost never unwillingness. It is an hour they do not have this week.

So treat this as competing for time, not overcoming resistance. Be specific about the length, offer a few concrete slots, and **consider a small gift card as a thank you**. A modest one converts a great deal of "sure, sometime" into an actual calendar entry, and nobody reads it as a bribe. Mention it in the original ask rather than afterward, so it removes the hesitation before it forms.

A note on interviewing customers you lost. Most people assume that call will be awkward. It rarely is. Buyers who chose someone else are often the most willing to talk and the most candid, and many appreciate being asked, because it leaves the door open. It is usually the most honest feedback you will get all year. If it still feels uncomfortable, we can run those conversations for you.

During the interview

The one rule that matters most

Read each main question out loud, word for word, exactly as it appears in the guide.

This is not about being formal. It is about the transcript. When the question appears verbatim in the recording, every answer can be matched back to the exact stage of the buying decision it belongs to. Without it, matching becomes guesswork, and it cannot be fixed after the fact.

Once you have read the question, the conversation can be as natural as you like. Probe, follow up, go off script, circle back. Only the main questions need to be read as written.

Get consent on the recording itself

Ask permission to record at the very top of the call, while you are already recording. Something like:

"Before we get started, I am recording this so I do not have to take notes. Are you okay with that?"

Some states require every participant to agree, so this is worth doing properly every time.

Let them ramble

Silence is productive. When someone trails off, wait rather than filling the gap. The most useful material in these interviews usually arrives right after a pause, when the person has run out of their prepared answer and starts thinking out loud.

Do not defend

If they say something critical about your product, your pricing, or your sales process, resist the urge to explain. The moment you defend, they stop telling you the truth. "Tell me more about that" is almost always the right response.

After the interview

Send us transcripts, not recordings

Export a text transcript from whatever tool you used. Zoom, Teams, Otter, Fathom, and Granola all do this.

Accepted formats: `.docx`, `.txt`, `.vtt`, `.srt`

Leave speaker labels on. Timestamps are fine, we strip them automatically.

Do not clean up the transcript

This is the one people get wrong most often.

The instinct is to tidy the grammar, cut the filler, and tighten the rambling. Please do not. The analysis is looking for how your buyer actually phrases things, in their words. A polished paraphrase replaces their language with yours, which quietly removes the exact signal this whole process exists to capture.

Send it raw. Messy is correct.

One file per interview

Do not combine several conversations into one document. Each interview is one person's decision process, and they need to stay separate.

Tell us who you spoke to

For each transcript, note:

FIELD	WHY IT MATTERS
Which group	Team, current customer, lost customer, or prospect. This drives the entire comparison and cannot be inferred from the transcript.
Their role	Whether they were the economic buyer, champion, evaluator, or blocker.
Company and rough size	Lets us see whether patterns differ by segment.
Date	Keeps the record straight if you interview the same person twice.

A simple file name convention handles most of this:

```
lost-customer_acme-manufacturing_ops-director_2026-08-12.docx
```

Quick checklist

Before the call:

- ☐ Interviewees chosen across the four customer types, plus lost customers
- ☐ Interview Guide downloaded and open
- ☐ Recording tool ready and tested
- ☐ 60 minutes blocked, not 30
- ☐ Thank-you gift card arranged, and mentioned when you asked

During:

- ☐ Consent captured on the recording
- ☐ Every main question read word for word
- ☐ Probed the interesting answers instead of moving on
- ☐ Did not defend or explain

After:

- ☐ Transcript exported as `.docx` , `.txt` , `.vtt` , or `.srt`
- ☐ Left completely unedited
- ☐ One file per interview
- ☐ Group, role, company, and date recorded
- ☐ Uploaded to Response Manager

Questions

Reach out any time at **info@assemblynetworks.net**. If you would rather have us facilitate some or all of the interviews, particularly the lost-customer conversations, just ask.